

TRADING IN TRUST

As India and Pakistan agree to reinvent relations, and Jammu and Kashmir gets into poll mode, the landmark cross-LoC trade could well be the new currency of peace between them

■ By Ramesh Vinayak in Srinagar

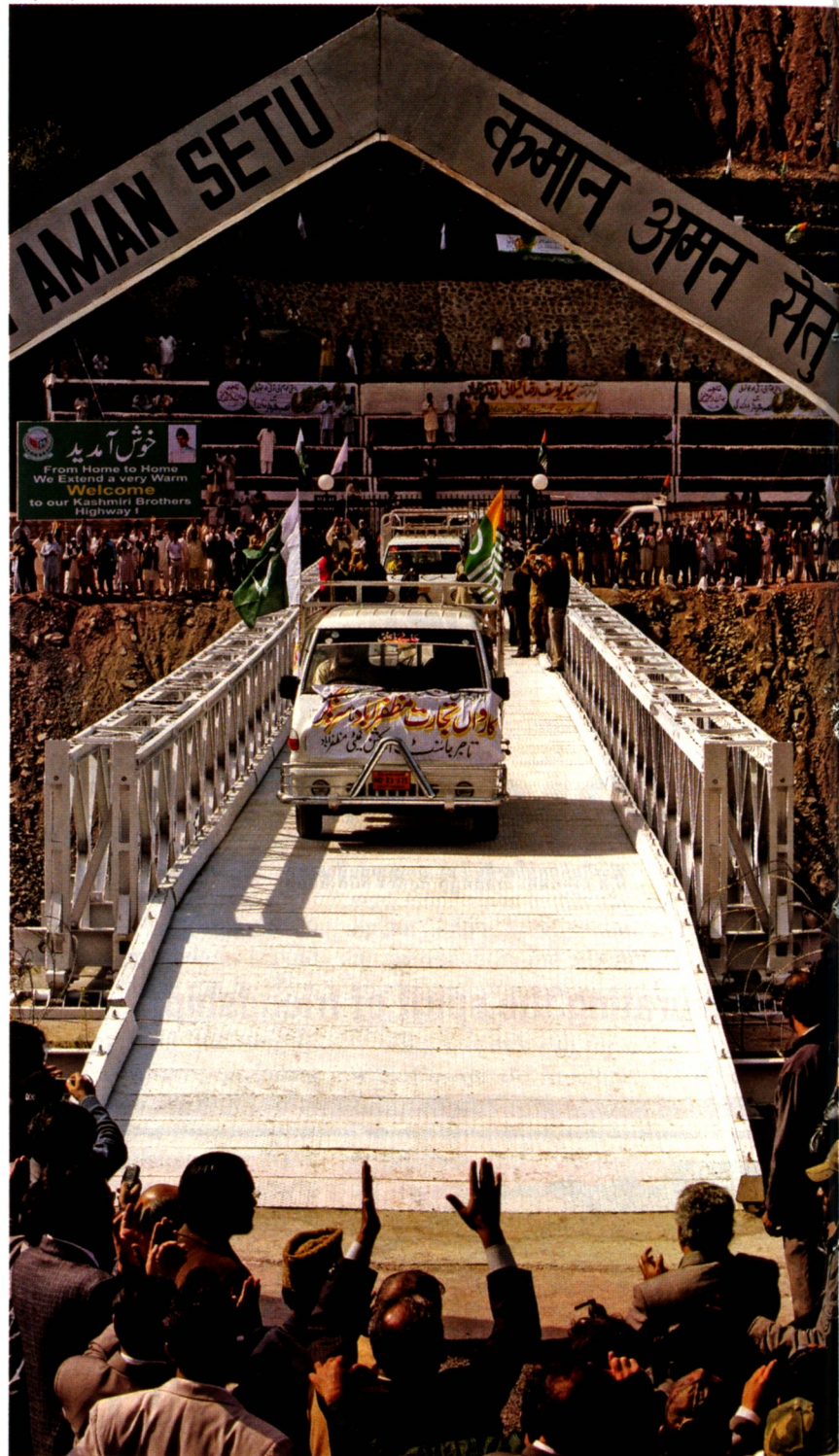
As the first winter snow glistened on the Pir Panjal mountains last week, Jammu and Kashmir warmed up to two unrelated but significant developments. Two days after the Election Commission announced an unusually-staggered seven-phase election, India and Pakistan started trade across the Line of Control (LoC) on the Uri-Muzaffarabad and Poonch-Rawalakote routes.

By timing both events simultaneously, New Delhi has rolled a double dice on the troubled state. While the Assembly elections are aimed at ending six months of political vacuum which witnessed resurgence of a pro-separatist frenzy in the Valley, the commencement of intra-Kashmir trade on the LoC is clearly in line with new paradigms laid down by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's mantra that "borders can't be redrawn but can be made meaningless", and Pakistan President Asif Ali Zardari's call to "reinvent ties" with India.

Having lived with a trade deficit so far, the two neighbours have finally embarked on pushing trading through a landmark move. It took Islamabad three years to agree to resume the traditional trade links which were snapped after a UN-mandated ceasefire line in 1948. It has emerged as the centrepiece of New Delhi's strategy to address both the internal and external aspects of the vexed Kashmir issue. It's also a measure of the newly struck chemistry between Singh and Zardari that both sides moved with unusual swiftness in making the cross-LoC trade operational four weeks after they greenlighted the ground-breaking initiative at their meeting in New York last month.

That the LoC—one of the most heavily-guarded borders—could become a new frontier of bonhomie and business was symbolically evident when a convoy of flower-bedecked 13 pick-up vans carrying the first consignment of Pakistani basmati rice and turmeric rolled over the iron bridge

Photographs by RAVI S SAHANI



BRIDGING THE GAP: The first trucks cross Aman Setu to an enthusiastic welcome